at the back of her throat. “*Kriminalinspektor* Kurt Reinhardt.”

Léa blinked. “I know that name. He’s a Gestapo officer.”

“How do you know that about him?”

“Josef told me that the sick bay reports I type, he then delivers to Reinhardt. He insists on knowing who is in the sick bay, for how long and when they will return to work. If a name stays on the report for more than a week, Reinhardt orders the person sent to a forced labor camp.”

A bone-deep fear coursed through Rose. Léa had confirmed what she’d suspected—that he was a powerful man who could determine the fate of others. “I wished I’d never spoken to him. I only wanted to help, but then it was like something inside him snapped and he changed. I hated making that awful Heil Hitler salute. I didn’t want to, but I feared if I didn’t—”

“Slow down. Start at the beginning. Tell me every detail, don’t leave anything out.” Worry flickered in Léa’s eyes. “Do you think he was following you, trying to make you betray others?”

“Oh no, I’m sure it was all by chance. He was grieving his brother’s death. He even cried. His pain was real. He felt so alone, almost desperate. He confided in me—a stranger—as if I was the only person he could talk to. Isn’t that sad?”

“Too many enemies. Not enough friends,” Léa said. “What did you tell him?”

“I did my best to console him, telling him about Maman and that I’m an orphan too . . .” She stopped. “You told me not to, but I thought here it wouldn’t matter so much.”

“Herr Reinhardt is an orphan?”

“That’s what he said. It was just him and his brother, Felix, like you and me. That’s why after he received the letter that Felix had been killed at the Battle of Stalingrad it tore him up.”

Rose went on to tell her about how he asked to see her work pass and told her he’d speak with the Meister at Archimedes so that she could have extra privileges. She pressed the heels of her hands against her eyes. “I told him I didn’t want him to do that, and that’s when he snapped, raising his voice, questioning if I was telling him what to do. When he made the Hitler salute, I felt I had to do the same.”

“It’s all right,” Léa said. “It would only have angered him more if you hadn’t done it.”